animals depend on external tissues such as the gills, skin and digestive mucosa to collectively regulate three homeostatic processes namely, osmotic regulation, ionic regulation and nitrogen excretion. Osmotic regulation is the control of tissue osmotic pressure which acts as a driving force for movement of water across biological membranes. Ionic regulation is the control of the ionic composition of body fluids. The process by which the body gets rid of the nitrogenous waste products of protein metabolism is called excretion. Nitrogen excretion is the pathway by which animals excrete ammonia, the toxic nitrogenous end product of protein catabolism. The removal of ammonia or other metabolic alternatives such as urea and uric acid is linked to ionic and osmotic homeostasis.

Fresh water vertebrates maintain higher salt concentrations in their body fluids; marine vertebrates maintain lower salt concentrations in their body fluids and terrestrial animals have more water in their body than the surrounding hence tend to lose water by evaporation. Osmoconformers are able to change their internal osmotic concentration with change in external environment as in marine molluscs and sharks. Osmoregulators maintain their internal osmotic concentration irrespective of their external osmotic environment (example: Otters). Depending on the ability to tolerate changes in the external environment, animals are classified as stenohaline and euryhaline. The stenohaline animals can tolerate only narrow fluctuations in the salt concentration (example: Gold fish), whereas the euryhaline animals are able to tolerate wide fluctuations in the salt concentrations eg., *Artemia, Tilapia* and Salmons.

The major nitrogenous waste products are ammonia, urea and uric acid. Other waste products of protein metabolism are trimethyl amine oxide (TMO) in marine teleosts, guanine in spiders, hippuric acid, allantonin, allantoic acid, ornithuric acid, creatinine, creatine, purines, pyramidines and pterines.

8.1 Modes of Excretion

Excretory system helps in collecting nitrogenous waste and expelling it into the external environment. Animals have evolved different strategies to get rid of these nitrogenous wastes. Ammonia produced during amino acid breakdown is toxic hence must be excreted either as ammonia, urea or uric acid. The type of nitrogenous end product an animal excretes depends upon the habitat of the animal. Ammonia requires large amount of water for its elimination, whereas uric acid, being the least toxic can be removed with the minimum loss of water, and urea can be stored in the body for considerable periods of time, as it is less toxic and less soluble in water than ammonia.

Animals that excrete most of its nitrogen in the form of ammonia are called **ammonoteles.** Many fishes, aquatic amphibians and aquatic insects are ammonotelic. In bony fishes, ammonia diffuses out across the body surface or through gill surface as ammonium ions. Reptiles, birds, land snails and insects excrete uric acid crystals, with

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